

MARKET INTELLIGENCE: REQUIREMENTS

Project: *U.S.-Ireland Research Translation and Commercialization Initiative*

1.0 Introduction:

The U.S.-Ireland Research & Development (R&D) Partnership (hereafter, the Partnership) supports trilateral U.S.-Ireland-Northern Ireland research teams to make synergistic impacts that advance science, health, and engineering. In alignment with the Belfast/Good Friday Agreement principles of “equality, partnership and mutual respect,” this unique intergovernmental partnership has become a model to facilitate trans-Atlantic research and development. After more than two decades of the Partnership, there is now an opportunity to achieve even greater impact by supporting researchers and students to develop the skills they need to translate their research for societal and economic benefit and help them progress at speed and scale through the lab-to-market pipeline.

Under the auspices of the Partnership, the U.S. National Science Foundation’s (NSF) Directorate for Technology, Innovation and Partnerships (TIP) and Office of International Science and Engineering (OISE) will lead a new trans-Atlantic research translation and commercialization initiative, in collaboration with partners Research Ireland (Republic of Ireland) and Department for the Economy (Northern Ireland, United Kingdom (UK)).

Since 2009, NSF, Research Ireland and the Department for the Economy have jointly funded between 70 to 100 U.S.-Ireland-Northern Ireland research projects in the areas of nanoscale science and engineering, sensors and sensor networks, telecommunications, energy and sustainability, and cybersecurity (see [NSF DCL 20-064](#)). The goal of the proposed research translation and commercialization activities is to leverage these existing investments to accelerate the translation of fundamental research into startups and small businesses and other commercial outcomes.

NSF seeks the support of a contractor with expertise in technology markets and research translation to support NSF in the development, execution, and oversight of activities to translate research for societal and economic benefit and help international teams of researchers and innovators accelerate innovation-to-impact. The contractor will serve as a point of contact for domestic and international teams and for NSF program staff. They will also be expected to leverage their research translation experience and technology market expertise within the U.S., Ireland, and Northern Ireland in furtherance of program goals.

The contractor will help NSF identify opportunities for research translation, formulate recommendations to support international teams, directly manage and fund research translation activities for the U.S.-based groups, and support international teams through training and mentorship (See Section 5.0 Performance Objectives for more detailed information.)

2.0 Period of Performance:

NSF anticipates a period of performance of up to four years from date of award.

3.0 Instrument and Approach

NSF is considering the potential use of an Other Transaction (OT) pursuant to NSF’s statutory authority at 42 U.S.C. § 19116(1). Other Transactions is not a FAR-based procurement contract nor a financial assistance transaction but another contracting mechanism available to NSF by statute.

NSF is exploring whether the flexibility of an OT may be appropriate given the anticipated need for adaptive program design, milestone-based support, and iterative engagement with participating teams. However, NSF has not made a final determination regarding the appropriate funding instrument.

Information submitted in response to this market intelligence may be used to inform NSF's acquisition strategy, including decisions regarding the appropriate funding instrument, competitive approach, and potential sources to be engaged. The market intelligence will be reviewed to better understand the capabilities of the marketplace and to identify organizations that may be well suited to support the described activities.

NSF may use responses to identify organizations that demonstrate the operational capacity, financial systems, and subject matter expertise necessary to execute the contemplated activities. NSF anticipates that any subsequent solicitation or competitive process may be limited to organizations identified through this market research process in accordance with any applicable laws and regulations. Participation in this RFI may therefore be a factor in determining eligibility for further consideration. However, this RFI does not constitute a solicitation or commitment by the Government in any manner.

4.0 Eligibility

This market intelligence is being issued for planning and market research purposes. Any responsible organization may submit information in response. Any responsible source (excluding foreign entities) may submit proposals for consideration. All offerors must be registered in the Federal Government's System for Award Management (SAM) prior to submitting a proposal (www.sam.gov). If a solicitation is released related to this RFI, a proposal may involve multiple organizations, but the proposal must be submitted by a lead organization with subcontracts to other participating organizations. Separately submitted collaborative proposals are not permitted. An eligible organization may submit a maximum of one proposal as a lead.

Only U.S. organizations may respond to this market intelligence request and/or be ultimately selected for funding.

Characteristics of a Strong Organization(s)

NSF seeks contractors with:

- Expertise in identifying emerging STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics) technologies with the highest potential for commercial success.
- Expertise in technology markets and research translation within the areas of artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, nanoscale science and engineering, advanced materials, biotechnology, sensors and sensor networks, telecommunications, and energy and sustainability.
- Experience working with U.S. federally-funded researchers, their labs, their institutions' technology transfer offices, and with scientific funding agencies such as NSF.
- Experience working with universities in Ireland and Northern Ireland and linkages to expert, technical and industrial networks in the European Union and the United Kingdom (UK).
- Experience assisting researchers in developing technology translation milestone plans and customized translation roadmaps.
- Experience coaching, mentoring and supporting researchers to achieve critical milestones to accelerate the translation of their research to commercial markets.
- Demonstrated success supporting the development of early-stage, high-tech startups.
- Demonstrated organizational capability to perform the work outlined.
- Demonstrated ability to employ qualified and knowledgeable staff/consultants capable of

- fulfilling the general requirements, including meeting all deliverables and support activities.
- The capacity to be responsive to changes in emerging and changing requirements, shifting priorities, and unexpected outcomes, and adapt as needed.

5.0 Performance Objectives

NSF seeks support for research teams across four major objectives:

- Objective 1: Proactively identify research with translation potential previously funded by NSF through the U.S.-Ireland Research and Development Partnership.
- Objective 2: Provide translation milestone plans, customized translation roadmaps, and expert mentorship to teams to help accelerate the translation of research for commercial and/or societal impacts.
- Objective 3: Provide funding and financial oversight to U.S. teams working with Ireland and Northern Ireland in the translation environment.
- Objective 4: Evaluate characteristics of the initiative and teams that contributed to the observed outcomes and summarize lessons learned.

Illustrative examples of contractor activities in support of these objectives are provided below. NSF welcomes other creative ideas for achieving this program's objectives, even if they are very different from the activity examples laid out below. NSF is particularly interested in ideas that appropriately balance bespoke solutions with efficiency and effectively deliver solutions for translating research for impact at speed and scale.

From a tactical perspective, NSF seeks a contractor that can develop and run the operational infrastructure, manage the day-to-day activities, serve as the main point of contact for the participating teams, and coalesce the key constituents and networks needed to support them. However, NSF does not expect it to be possible to specify all requirements at the time of the award in clear, specific, objective and measurable terms though NSF also emphasizes that all performance must be done in accordance with any agreement terms, including any modification and change provisions. Consequently, NSF also seeks a thought partner who will work closely with the NSF program team to develop, implement, and oversee the overall program of activities. NSF is interested in forging a relationship that allows NSF and its selected contractor to engage with NSF in decision making in response to emerging and changing requirements, shifting priorities and unexpected outcomes.

To meet Objective 1:

- Illustrative activities may include leading the review process for selecting and managing potential translation projects in coordination with NSF, Research Ireland and the Department for the Economy.
- Each project will be reviewed by experts identified and managed by the contractor with technical and entrepreneurship/translation expertise.
- Experts will adhere to NSF's conflict of interest policies for reviewers: [OGC - Panelist Conflict of Interest Training | NSF - National Science Foundation](#).
- The contractor will assess projects based on criteria that could include:
 - Robust team with complementary expertise and enthusiasm to learn;
 - Potential for economic impact;
 - Potential for societal impact;
 - Potential for sustained impact beyond this funding opportunity; and

- Technology readiness.
- The contractor will share project selection recommendations with NSF and other funding agencies for approval.
- Illustrative activities may include conveying and supporting up to two interactive workshops (a kickoff and final convening) that will bring together approximately 60-80 representatives including:
 - Translation training program teams;
 - Researchers and students;
 - Translation experts and entrepreneurs;
 - Industry representatives;
 - Investors; and
 - Government agencies.
- The contractor may play a key role in setting the agenda, identifying and inviting experts and moderating sessions for both workshops, and summarizing the feedback of the participants. Such workshops are intended to:
 - Enable applicants to design and get feedback on their translation proposals, ask questions, and learn more about the program and how it can benefit them;
 - Catalyze new industry collaborations and commercialization opportunities;
 - Enable discussion of potential solutions to shared challenges related to the translation of research; and
 - Facilitate sharing of opportunities for continued support along the translation path.

To meet Objective 2:

Illustrative activities may include the production of a specific translation milestone plan by assigning translation and market-specific experts to work closely with selected teams to provide individualized mentorship and customized roadmaps to help them advance along the translation pathway.

- The contractor should coach, mentor and support the selected teams and may work with their institutions' leadership and/or technology transfer offices to achieve the translation milestones contained in their plans.
- While this engagement will vary according to team stage, technology and other considerations, the roadmaps may include specific actions related to:
 - intellectual property,
 - customer discovery,
 - expert entrepreneurial engagement,
 - product definition,
 - export control,
 - data security,
 - competitive landscape, and
 - market research.
- Experts with knowledge of local markets and needs should be identified through the contractor's networks as well as through the funding agencies and other sources, as determined by the contractor.
- Mentorship could include next-stage training programs, such as the NSF Innovation Corps (NSF I-CorpsTM) program or relevant European Union or UK programs.

To meet Objective 3:

NSF is envisioning a contractor that can provide selected U.S.-based research groups with funding and financial oversight to support 36 months of research translation activities. Teams would be considered successful when they enhance skills related to translating their research to the market and measurably advance their technology towards translation, recognizing that failing fast and pivoting are viable options.

Successful research translation for each team need not follow a linear path and may require flexibility to adjust to both market and technical pivots.

- The level of success will vary depending on one or more of the following, as well as additional contractor-suggested criteria:
 - the starting point of the team;
 - the focal technology and other factors;
 - greater understanding of markets, value propositions, and available supports;
 - development of go-to-market strategies and fundraising plans;
 - improved intellectual property protections or positions;
 - advances in product development; andnew licensing agreements or startup formations.

To meet Objective 4:

- The contractor will summarize progress through quarterly updates, annual written reports a comprehensive final written report and a presentation, which will be provided to the funding agencies. In these reports, the contractor should consider:
 - project or team characteristics that facilitated advancement (or fast failure/pivot) along the translation pathway
 - lessons learned with an eye towards scalability,
 - the balance between bespoke solutions with general approaches to deliver solutions for mentoring teams and translating research for impact efficiently, sustainably and on a reduced budget
 - options for connecting to or leveraging other NSF programs or investments.
- Further, the contractor should assess how the international aspect of the initiative impacted the process and outcomes in both positive and negative ways, including how those may be approached or revised going forward.

6.0 Illustrative Deliverables Under Consideration

NSF is seeking feedback on potential deliverables that could be included in a future solicitation. Illustrative activities may include:

- Supporting and/or facilitating in two or more workshops/convenings located in the Republic of Ireland, Northern Ireland, and/or the U.S.
- Design and administration of a review process for all potential applicants and providing recommendations regarding projects with the highest translational potential and/or unique gaps and opportunities for exploration.
- Developing translation milestone plans, customized translation roadmaps, and expert mentorship to selected teams to advance research translation objectives.
- Issue and manage the subcontracts/subawards that fund the translation activities of the U.S.-based research groups.
- Collecting programmatic and performance data and regular conversations with teams, provide quarterly updates, annual written reports, and a comprehensive written final report to NSF (format to be provided).
- Preparing a strategic written analysis of lessons learned document that includes ideas for how aspects of this activity could be efficiently and cost-effectively scaled up or connected to other NSF programs and/or investments in the future.

7.0 Information Requested from Respondents

To assist NSF in understanding the current marketplace and organizational capabilities, respondents are encouraged to describe:

1. Prior experience supporting research translation or commercialization programs funded by federal or other governmental entities.
2. Experience administering or overseeing funding to third-party performers (e.g., subawards, milestone-based payments, or similar structures).
3. Experience coordinating programs involving U.S. and EU and/or UK-based research institutions.
4. Organizational approaches to conflict-of-interest management in project review or advisory contexts.
5. Financial and administrative systems used to manage federal or public funds.
6. Examples of measurable outcomes achieved in prior translation or commercialization initiatives.

Responses should be descriptive in nature and are intended solely to inform NSF's understanding of available capabilities.

8.0 Instruction for Respondents

Please submit all responses to this RFI to rscsolicitations@nsf.gov with the subject line "*U.S.-Ireland Research Translation and Commercialization Initiative*" by April 13, 2026, at 3:00 PM EDT.

Any information received becomes the property of the Government and will not be returned to the submitter. NSF may share responses with other parts of the Government or unattributable portions of responses outside of the Government, including with Research Ireland and the Department for the Economy, as helpful in finalizing the design or implementation of the program. Responses may also be subject to mandatory disclosure under the Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) or as otherwise required by law.

9.0 Agency Contacts

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